MIDHUN VIJAYAN



T.S. KALYANARAMAN, 71
Thrissur, Kerala

Company
Kalyan Jewellers Ltd

Net Worth
Rs 6,200 crore

A GLITTERING EXAMPLE

The man who is known as the 'gold king of India' has had an epic journey in Kerala's business world. Kalyanaraman was introduced to the family textiles business in Thrissur when he was 12 and started serving customers at their clothing store in his free time. Born in a Tamil Brahmin family, young Kalyanaraman used to accompany his father daily to the store. It was his grandfather who taught him his first and most important lesson in business—that the customer is king. He ventured into the crowded retail jewellery space in 1993, setting up his first shop in Thrissur with Rs 75 lakh.

Today, the Kalyan Group has 122 showrooms and 650 My Kalyan customer service outlets and mini diamond stores across India and West Asia. Kalyan has introduced new benchmarks in jewellery retailing—they were among the first to launch BIS standards of jewellery certification and price tags for their collections. Kalyan has also spent big to get movie stars like Amitabh Bachchan, Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, Nagarjuna Akkineni and Manju Warrier as brand ambassadors.

Where he invests profits
In realty and in business expansion

Sons Rajesh and Ramesh are now executive directors of the group. Rajesh looks after finance and operations, while Ramesh oversees the marketing, sales and HR functions.

"Our customers and their loyalty to Kalyan are the keys to our success," says Kalyanaraman.

The patriarch still likes to attend to customers at his Thrissur showrooms whenever he happens to be around. He has been a practitioner of yoga since the 1960s. The tycoon's Rolls Royce Phantom, three private jets—including a latest Embraer Legacy 650—and luxury home with a private helipad in Thrissur's Sobha City are the talk of the temple town.

-Jeemon Jacob